NEW STAKEHOLDERS

The fragmentation of India's national political parties and the rise of regional, identity-based formations have changed India's foreign policy discourse drastically since the days when the Indian National Congress held sway over the country's politics. Political parties are critical to setting agendas in every parliamentary democracy. The rise of coalition governments and the gradual devolution in the social and economic arenas to the states within the Indian Union has resulted in states becoming new stakeholders even in the realm of foreign policy.

India is the only state in South Asia that borders all its neighbours and hence those states that share a border with India's neighbours have often treated ties with those neighbours as a domestic issue. What this has often meant is that the vagaries of domestic politics now affect foreign policy. India's ties with Sri Lanka and especially the Tamil question have been affected by the views of the party in power in the southern state of Tamil Nadu. Similarly, it took India decades to resolve the land border issues with Bangladesh and sign the border agreement in June 2015.[54]

Devolution of financial power to the state governments and economic growth in states has led some states, like Gujarat, Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra, to have a higher economic growth rate than the federal government. These states have also started building their own ties with not only neighbouring countries but also with countries far away. For example, when he was chief minister of Gujarat, Narendra Modi travelled to China and Japan. Singapore is the leading investor in the construction of the new capital of Andhra Pradesh after the creation of India's twenty-ninth state Telangana.[55]

New technology and methods of communication have had their impact on foreign policy as well. Today governments do not wait for long telegrams or dispatches from their embassies when television, smartphones and social media provide them with the latest information. Critics may